

WEIRD WORLD

THE ROMANS BELIEVED THAT THE WARM BLOOD OF A SLAUGHTERED GLADIATOR WOULD CURE EPILEPSY—AN ILLNESS THAT AFFECTS THE NERVOUS SYSTEM.

Ordinary gladiators were lucky if they made it into the double digits before biting the dust.

Unfair fights

The secret of Commodus's success was the fact that he was the Emperor. His opponents knew that humiliating him in public would result in their certain death. Commodus also reenacted popular myths, such as the story of Hercules' battle with snake-legged giants. He made some men who had lost their feet play the giants. They had only sponges to throw instead of rocks, and he killed them with a club. He also executed wild animals. During one 14-day bloodbath, he slaughtered 100 bears from the safety of the arena.

Commodus, the emperor-gladiator, is just one example of how much influence gladiators

had in Roman society—all the way to the top. But how did Rome's terrifying terminators come about? Well, the story of gladiators goes hand in hand with Rome's development from a cluster of tiny villages into the greatest power of the ancient world.



COMMODUS MODELED HIMSELF ON HERCULES—THE LEGENDARY STRONGMAN AND SLAYER OF MONSTERS—BY WEARING A LION-SKIN CLOAK AND CARRYING A CLUB.